no choice. The promised reinforcements from 67 Brigade had not materialized as yet; the previous evening 5 Guards had fought a running battle with the Chinese at Thembang and then gone off the radar after they were told to fall back. His remaining two battalions, 1 Sikh LI and 1 Madras (both minus a company) were deployed around Bomdila, but the brigadier knew that his defences were far from adequate.

In the beginning of November when the focus was entirely on Se-la, 48 Brigade had moved in to occupy Bomdila. With Pathania deciding to set up his HQ at Dirang Dzong and, in the process, deploying 65 Brigade around himself, a second layer of defence had been created between Se-la and Bomdila. This resulted in a false sense of security and pushed the latter's defence requirements further down the priority list. Within a couple of days of the brigade's arrival at Bomdila, Division HQ's focus had shifted to Poshing-la. With the initial dispatch of the 5 Guards column under Captain Amarjeet to block off the pass, it was clear that Thembang would now be the screen position. When the Chinese attack came, it would have to be halted at Thembang with Bomdila being the firm base at the rear.

Unfortunately, ever since Niranjan Prasad had been replaced by Anant Pathania, the prevailing assumption in 4 Division (and IV Corps and Army HQ) was that with the Chinese having captured Tawang, the 'war' was over. The return of Kaul as GOC IV Corps hardly helped matters. Even though he had been declared medically fit, a family member confirms that 'he fought the rest of the war in great pain'. After his return, Kaul visited Se-la just once, and had made it abundantly clear that he did not expect any major Chinese activity till next spring. Had there existed even the slightest inkling that the Chinese would launch a full-fledged assault within a month of the initial attack on 7 Brigade on the Nam Ka Chu, it is doubtful that Kaul would have allowed Pathania to descend from Senge, headache or no headache.

Pathania certainly did not expect the Chinese to progress beyond the odd skirmish here and there. So set in this view was the GOC that he refused to believe the initial reports from 4 Garhwal that the Chinese were moving men in numbers to outflank Se-la. The very fact that Dirang Dzong had not prepared basic defences to fight the Chinese are clear pointers towards the prevailing mind set.

The mild-mannered Gurbax Singh now regretted that he too had taken the soft option. On arrival at Bomdila, Gurbax had shifted into the